

Built For The Environment:

The Making Of Semakau Landfill

By reducing the volume of solid waste by 90 percent, incineration initially provided a means of extending the lifespan of Singapore's landfills. But as the economy and population continued to grow in the 1980s, it became apparent that all existing landfills would be depleted by the turn of the century.

The search for a new solid waste disposal site in the mid-1980s led the Ministry of the Environment to consider Punggol, an area filled with swamps and pig farms, as a possible landfill. This plan was subsequently rejected, as it was thought that the land would serve the needs of Singaporeans better as a new residential and commercial centre. The area is now the site of Punggol New Town. In the spirit of inter-agency cooperation, the Ministry agreed to forego the idea, while the Housing and Development Board provided technical help in the interim period to extend the lifespan of the Lorong Halus Dumping Ground.

The opportunity costs of setting up a new landfill in other parts of the mainland were similarly deemed too high, given Singapore's projected land needs for future housing, industry and recreation. An offshore solution was thus mooted. As islands such as Pulau Ubin in the north and the Southern Islands near Sentosa were earmarked for tourism or recreational purposes, the sea space between Pulau Sakeng and Pulau Semakau was suggested as a potential location for an offshore landfill.